

WEEKLY JOURNAL DIGEST

Weekly journal digest for 2026-07-06 to 2026-07-12

Curated articles in political communication and computational social science.

SUMMARY

This week's COMAP Journal Bot scan gathered 269 candidates and curated 23 new papers plus 17 previous-week catch-ups. The strongest cluster is methodological: LLM-assisted coding, content-level exposure measurement, personalized-intervention testing, ecological inference, and network diffusion all offer tools that can travel across computational communication and political science projects.

The substantive papers connect those methods to platform governance, state communication, institutional inequality, public policy, digital consumer protection, and the unequal effects of platform expansion. Several broad-journal items are included because they provide unusually direct evidence or infrastructure for COMAP's research agenda.

- LLMs appear both as research instruments and as tools for institutional accountability.
- Platform effects span state messaging, consumer protection, food delivery, polarization, and democratic infrastructure.
- Behavioral science papers show how research moves into federal policy design and evaluation.

HIGHLIGHTS

Introducing HALC: a general pipeline for the systematic and reliable construction of prompts for automated coding with LLMs in the computational social sciences

COMMUNICATION METHODS AND MEASURES · 2026-07-07

Why it matters · HALC directly addresses prompt construction as a measurement problem, offering a systematic workflow for more reliable LLM-based coding in computational social science.

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Beyond apps: a method to model full distributions of screen content over time to study media effects

COMMUNICATION METHODS AND MEASURES · 2026-07-10

Why it matters · This method moves exposure measurement beyond app-level logs toward the actual mix of content people encounter, which is closer to the causal object in contemporary media-effects research.

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Assessing corporate sustainability with large language models: evidence from Europe

NATURE COMMUNICATIONS · 2026-07-07

Why it matters · The paper turns 2.9 million extracted ESG observations into an open framework for auditing corporate disclosure and performance, a useful model for large-scale policy text measurement.

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User interaction with digital platforms: A consumer protection perspective

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-07-06

Why it matters · The FTC cases connect platform design, advertising disclosure, complaint systems, and empirical behavioral research to concrete digital-market oversight.

[Open article →](#)

Multiplexing in networks and diffusion

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-07-10

Why it matters · Field evidence from Indian villages shows that overlapping relationship layers can either accelerate or impede diffusion depending on the contagion process, sharpening how social networks should be measured.

[Open article →](#)

Feeding health inequality through platform-based food delivery in China

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-07-06

Why it matters · The staggered platform rollout reveals how equal access to digital convenience can produce unequal downstream outcomes across income groups.

[Open article →](#)

Monotone Ecological Inference

POLITICAL ANALYSIS · 2026-07-10

Why it matters · This political-methodology contribution is especially relevant for researchers recovering individual behavior from aggregate electoral or demographic data under defensible shape constraints.

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Quantifying institutional gender inequality in contemporary visual art

NATURE COMMUNICATIONS · 2026-07-09

Why it matters · The paper brings computational measurement to institutional inequality in a visual cultural field, aligning with COMAP interests in multimodal evidence and representation.

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Previous Week Catch-Up

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COLLECTION SNAPSHOT

TOTAL COLLECTED CANDIDATES 269	NEW THIS WEEK CANDIDATES 127	PREVIOUS WEEK CATCH-UP CANDIDATES 142
LATE ADDITIONS CANDIDATES 0	CURATED DIGEST BELOW 23 new, 17 catch-up, 0 late additions	NOTE The full collected set above is before manual relevance filtering, while the attached PDF reflects the curated digest.

FULL CURATED DIGEST

New This Week

Communication Methods and Measures

Beyond apps: a method to model full distributions of screen content over time to study media effects

2026-07-10 · DOI 10.1080/19312458.2026.2697199

Yikun Chi; Mu-Jung Cho; Kimberly M. Molaib; Xiaoran Sun; Thomas N. Robinson; Nilam Ram; Byron Reeves

Academia Sinica; Stanford University; University of Minnesota-Twin Cities; University of Washington

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.[Read article →](#)**Introducing HALC: a general pipeline for the systematic and reliable construction of prompts for automated coding with LLMs in the computational social sciences**

2026-07-07 · DOI 10.1080/19312458.2026.2693637

Andreas Reich; Claudia Thoms; Tobias Schrimpf

University of Hohenheim

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.[Read article →](#)

Communication Research

Chatbots and Loneliness: How Linguistic Dynamics in Conversations with Chatbots Shape Young Adults' Loneliness

2026-07-10 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261466012

Jinyoung Choi; Catalina L. Toma

University of Wisconsin-Madison, USA

Abstract. This study theorizes and tests language-based mechanisms through which conversations with chatbots can shape users' loneliness. Lonely college students (N = 96) engaged in emotionally meaningful conversations with the chatbot Replika daily for one week. Results showed a small but significant decrease in users' loneliness from baseline to post-test. Linguistic analyses revealed two distinct well-being pathways. When participants used more positive emotion language, so did the chatbot, which was linked to higher positive daily affect and lower post-study loneliness. Conversely, when participants used more negative emotion language, so did the chatbot, which was linked to lower positive daily affect and higher post-study loneliness. Findings provide evidence for an expression effect, where users' own positive (but not negative) linguistic framing shapes their well-being, and a chatbot-response effect, where chatbots mirror and amplify users' emotional tone. This study theorizes chatbots as emotional mirrors with dual potential to alleviate or exacerbate users' loneliness.

[Read article →](#)

Do Profile Photos Enhance Vicarious Intergroup Contact? Testing Theoretical Perspectives from Social Identity, the Social Identity Model of Deindividuation Effects (SIDE), and Social Presence

2026-07-06 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261466759

Yue (Nancy) Dai; Lunrui Fu; Wufan Jia

City University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong; Nanyang Technological University, Singapore; Tsinghua University, Hong Kong

Abstract. Profile photos are ubiquitous in online environments, yet little is known about how they shape observers' impressions when mediated interactions involve members of different social groups. This experiment (N = 1,661) examined how profile photos influence impressions formed during observed intergroup exchanges in news comment sections. A 2 x 2 design (topic photo) tested mechanisms derived from Social Identity Theory (SIT), the Social Identity Model of Deindividuation Effects (SIDE), and Social Presence Theory. Results showed that profile photos heightened awareness of the relevant group distinction and, through identification with the ingroup commenter, led to more positive outgroup responses—but only when the photos clearly conveyed the group difference central to the interaction. When both interpersonal and intergroup processes were modeled together, only the intergroup pathway remained supported. These findings clarify how profile photos shape mediated impressions and identify cue diagnosticity as key for enhancing vicarious intergroup contact.

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Journal of Communication

Media emotion regulation and executive functions: individual differences in temporal ordering among young children

2026-07-09 · DOI 10.1093/JOC/JQAG009

Jane Shawcross; McCall A Booth; Chris L Porter; Megan Van Alfen; Megan Gale; Lara A Maximiano; Elena K Holmes; Sarah M Coyne; Hailey G Holmgren; Blake L Jones

Department of Human Development and Family Studies, Utah State University, Logan, UT,; Department of Psychology, Brigham Young University, Provo, UT,; Department of Psychology, Georgetown University, Washington, D.C.,; School of Communication, The Ohio State University, Columbus, OH,; School of Family Life, Brigham Young University, Provo, UT,

Abstract. Abstract Using media to help children regulate difficult emotions (also called regulatory media use) is a process linked to the development of children's executive functions. Although a necessary condition for establishing causality, the temporal ordering of the relationship between regulatory media use and executive functions has not been explicitly studied. In this study, we examined individual differences in the temporal ordering of the association between regulatory media use and executive functions using data from six waves of Project M.E.D.I.A. (spanning 2.5 years old to 7.5 years old). Three classes of temporal ordering were identified: Media Emotion Regulation Driven (7.00%), Bidirectional (87.36%), and Diverging Temporal Ordering (6.00%). Parent depression was negatively associated with the probability of children being classified in the Bidirectional class but was positively associated with the probability of children being classified in the Media Emotion Regulation Driven class.

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Nature Communications

The intersecting effects of race/ethnicity, wealth, education, and gender on AIDS among 28.3 million Brazilians

2026-07-09 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-73892-6

Iracema Lua; Laio Magno; Andrea F. Silva; Priscila FPS Gestal; Joao Luiz Bastos; Gabriela Jesus; Ronaldo de Almeida Coelho; Maria Yury Ichihara; Mauricio L. Barreto; Carlos AS Teles Santos; Corrina Moucheraud; Pamina M. Gorbach; James Macinko; Luis Eugenio Souza; Davide Rasella; Ines Dourado

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Quantifying institutional gender inequality in contemporary visual art

2026-07-09 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-71470-4

Xindi Wang; Alexander J. Gates; Magnus Resch; Albert-Laszlo Barabasi

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Urbanization processes widen global divergence in extreme temperature variability

2026-07-08 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-75457-Z

Renlu Qiao; Fangzheng Li; Tao Wu; Zeyin Chen; Xiang AO; Xi Meng; Jingkai Zhao; Zhiqiang Wu; Borong Lin; Yue Zhang

Abstract. Abstract Extreme temperature variability (ETV) is a key dimension of climate risk for billions of residents. However, how urbanization shapes global ETV divergence remains unclear. Here, we assemble a 1950-2020 panel of 10,522 cities and demonstrate that ETV trajectories diverge by development status as measured by the human development index (HDI). ETV intensifies in high-development cities, whereas it slowly weakens in low-development cities, resulting in a current gap of roughly 1.66 C. Decomposing ETV into event frequency and intensity reveals that cumulative ETV is driven mainly by intensity. Using an interpretable machine-learning framework, we find that aerosols are the urban factor most strongly associated with ETV after controlling for climate and geography. Blue-green space is consistently associated with lower ETV, whereas urban morphology has a smaller and context-dependent effect. These findings link global ETV inequality to urban governance and support targeted management that focusses on limiting volatility under climate risk.

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Assessing corporate sustainability with large language models: evidence from Europe

2026-07-07 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-75160-Z

Kerstin Forster; Lucas Keil; Victor Wagner; Maximilian A. Muller; Thorsten Sellhorn; Stefan Feuerriegel

Abstract. Abstract Companies play a crucial role in achieving global sustainability goals, yet evidence on their progress across environmental, social, and governance (ESG) dimensions remains limited. We develop a machine learning framework to systematically extract ESG indicators from corporate reports. Applying this approach to annual and sustainability reports of 600 large European firms (2014-2023), we construct a dataset of 2.9 million ESG observations across environmental, social, and governance topics. We assess ESG transparency based on disclosures aligned with the European Sustainability Reporting Standards (ESRS) and evaluate ESG performance using extracted numerical indicators. Results reveal a pronounced transparency gap: firms in the top ESG rating decile disclose 22% more indicators than those in the bottom decile, although this gap narrows over time. Performance trends are uneven: while most social indicators remain largely stagnant, except for gains in gender equality, environmental indicators show some improvement. Reported scope 3 emissions increase sharply, largely reflecting improved disclosure. Our open-source framework enables systematic tracking of corporate ESG efforts.

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Nature Human Behaviour

Stable intuition and the rise of deliberative prosociality in childhood

2026-07-06 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02487-4

Francesco Margoni; Francesco Nava; Chiara Sotis; Matthew R. Levy; Valerio Capraro; Elena Nava

Abstract. Abstract We examine how social behaviours emerge and stabilize across childhood. A sample of 537 Italian-speaking children (3-10 years) were randomly assigned to respond under time pressure (intuitive) or time delay (deliberative) in social decision tasks (Public Goods, Dictator, Ultimatum, Deception and Moral Dilemmas). Factor analysis identified three latent dimensions: Prosociality (cooperative, altruistic and honest actions), Social Optimism (beliefs about others' cooperation) and Acquiescence (tendency to accept offers). Intuitive responses were more prosocial than deliberative ones in early childhood ($= 0.66$; 95% CI = (0.35, 0.97)), but this difference diminished with age ($= 0.11$; 95% CI = (0.18, 0.05)). We found no evidence that Social Optimism varied across age or decision mode, whereas Acquiescence declined with age ($= 0.14$; 95% CI = (0.19, 0.10)). These findings suggest a developmental shift whereby prosocial behaviour is initially driven by intuitive responses and gradually becomes embedded within reflective, deliberative decision-making systems, as cooperative dispositions stabilize across childhood.

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Political Analysis

Monotone Ecological Inference

2026-07-10 · DOI 10.1017/PAN.2026.10048

Hadi Elzayn; Jacob Goldin; Cameron Guage; Daniel Ho; Claire Morton

Columbia University; Stanford Law School; The University of Chicago; University of California Berkeley

Abstract. Abstract We study the identification of individual-level associations when only aggregate data are available. We characterize the biases of, and relationships among, canonical ecological inference (EI) estimators. We use these results to develop a partial identification approach: monotone EI. The approach exploits information about one or both of the following conditional associations: (1) outcome differences between groups within the same neighborhood and (2) outcome differences within the same group between neighborhoods with different group compositions. We show how assumptions about the sign of these conditional associations, whether individually or in relation to one another, can yield informative sharp bounds. We illustrate our results using county-level data to study differences in COVID-19 vaccination rates among Republicans and Democrats in the United States.

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Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

Multiplexing in networks and diffusion

2026-07-10 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2534923123

Arun G. Chandrasekhar; Vasu Chaudhary; Benjamin Golub; Matthew O. Jackson

Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab; Department of Economics, Northwestern University; Department of Economics, Stanford University; National Bureau of Economic Research; Santa Fe Institute

Abstract. We study multiplexing-the extent to which people have multiple, distinct types of relationships with the same others. We document empirical multiplexing patterns in Indian village data. We show that relationships such as socializing, advising, helping, and lending are correlated but distinct, while commonly used proxies for networks based on ethnicity and geography are nearly uncorrelated with actual relationships. We also show that these layers and their overlap affect information diffusion in a field experiment. On the theoretical side, we show that increased overlap in people's different types of relationships impedes the spread of simple contagions-such as diseases or basic information that spread through a single interaction. In contrast, such higher levels of multiplexing enhance the spread of a complex contagion (e.g., a behavior or belief that requires multiple interactions for transmission) when infection rates are low, but impede complex contagion if infection rates are high. Finally, we identify empirical differences in multiplexing by gender and connectedness.

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Why human societies adopt rigid moral rules: The efficiency-robustness trade-off

2026-07-08 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2535467123

Julien Lie-Panis; Leo Fitouchi; Nicolas Baumard; Jean-Baptiste Andre

Department of Brain and Cognitive Sciences, Massachusetts Institute of Technology; Department of Psychology, University of Guelph; Department of Social and Behavioral Sciences, Institute for Advanced Studies in Toulouse, Toulouse School of Economics, University of Toulouse Capitole; Institut Jean Nicod, Departement d'etudes Cognitives, Ecole Normale Supérieure, Université Paris Sciences & Lettres, Ecole des hautes études en sciences sociales; Max Planck Research Group Dynamics of Social Behavior, Max Planck Institute for Evolutionary Biology

Abstract. Humans are capable of remarkably flexible moral judgment. Yet societies rely on rigid rules-obligations and prohibitions that apply categorically, even when case-by-case reasoning could yield better outcomes. Why would a species capable of flexibility bind itself to rigid rules? We propose that rigid rules arise as social technologies for managing ambiguity about noncooperation. People often have legitimate reasons for failing to cooperate, yet those reasons are typically opaque to observers, allowing opportunists to disguise selfishness as justified hardship. We formalize this idea with a game-theoretic model. Two cooperative equilibria emerge: a flexible norm that accommodates legitimate excuses but is vulnerable to exploitation, and a rigid norm that closes this loophole by mandating cooperation even when inefficient. Comparing these equilibria reveals an efficiency-robustness trade-off: Flexibility maximizes welfare when trust is secure, whereas rigidity preserves cooperation when trust is fragile. This explains why rigid rules prevail in interactions with strangers, formal institutions, or in tight societies, while flexibility is more common when trust is secure.

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User interaction with digital platforms: A consumer protection perspective

2026-07-06 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2525996123

Nellie Lew; Devesh R. Raval

Federal Trade Commission

Abstract. The rapid growth of digital platforms has transformed how consumers interact with the marketplace and led to new challenges for consumer protection. This Perspective describes how the Federal Trade Commission's Bureau of Economics uses behavioral insights and empirical methods to support efforts to prevent unfair or deceptive business practices in digital markets. We highlight two studies that address critical knowledge gaps in digital consumer protection, including how consumers perceive and respond to advertising disclosures and how digital design choices affect the accessibility and effectiveness of consumer reporting tools. The studies illustrate how behavioral research can be used both prospectively, to evaluate potential remedies, and retrospectively, to assess the effects of past Federal Trade Commission (FTC) actions. The first study is a laboratory experiment that examines how the salience of advertising disclosures influences consumer recognition of and engagement with advertising content, where engagement is defined as the time users spend viewing ads. The second is a retrospective analysis of a redesigned consumer complaint website, using a natural experiment to evaluate the effect of usability improvements on complaint submission rates and information quality. Together, these studies demonstrate how applied research on user behavior can inform marketplace oversight and the design of consumer-facing tools. We conclude by outlining ongoing efforts to expand the role of empirical research at the FTC to strengthen the foundation for evidence-based policymaking in an increasingly complex digital environment.

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Turning policy implications into policy impact: Lessons from behavioral science in financial markets

2026-07-06 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2525990123

Alycia Chin; Katherine G. Carman; Adam W. Craig; Jonathan A. Cook; David B. Zimmerman

U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission, Office of the Investor Advocate; University of Kentucky, Gatton College of Business and Economics

Abstract. We describe how research can inform policymaking. We begin by summarizing the policy formation process, offering a framework illustrating how interactions between scientists and policymakers can provide mutual benefits. We then describe four research initiatives from the Securities and Exchange Commission's Office of Investor Research (OIR) as examples of how behavioral sciences can help inform policymakers. The first initiative established a probability-based nationally representative survey panel focused on US investor behavior. The remaining three examined investor communications for mutual fund benchmarks, emerging annuities (known as registered index-linked annuities), and mutual fund fee visuals. We conclude by synthesizing our work and describing practices that can help scientists have policy impact, not just policy implications.

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The role of nonfinancial factors in the Congressional Budget Office's health insurance coverage projections

2026-07-06 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2525991123

Nianyi Hong; Ben Hopkins

Congressional Budget, Health Analysis Division, Health Insurance Modeling Unit

Abstract. Nonfinancial factors play an important role in people's coverage decisions as premiums, cost sharing, and other factors that determine the financial value of health insurance cannot fully explain patterns in take-up rates. The Congressional Budget Office (CBO) is tasked with estimating the budgetary and coverage effects of policy and economic changes that affect health insurance markets, which includes considering the interactions between nonfinancial factors and policy design. The agency groups the nonfinancial factors it considers into three categories: ease of enrollment, awareness, and attitudes. Many recent policies have affected nonfinancial factors related to the take-up of Medicaid and marketplace insurance, such as the introduction of work requirements for Medicaid and access to zero-premium marketplace plans. This article explains how nonfinancial factors are handled and incorporated into CBO's baseline health insurance projections and cost estimates, highlights the recent literature on the effect of these nonfinancial factors on insurance take-up decisions, and suggests future areas of research.

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Science in service: Behavioral research applications across federal agencies

2026-07-06 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2608196123

Alycia Chin; Baruch Fischhoff

Carnegie Mellon Institute for Strategy and Technology, Carnegie Mellon University; Department of Engineering and Public Policy, Carnegie Mellon University; U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission, Office of the Investor Advocate

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Payment integrity in government programs: Takeaways from incorporating the behavioral sciences in US federal evaluations

2026-07-06 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2525993123

Maya Duru; Hanna Hoover; Heather Barry Kappes; David Schwegman; Brigitte Seim; Mattie Toma; Mary Clair Turner

Better Government Lab, McCourt School of Public Policy, Georgetown University; Department of Management, London School of Economics and Political Science; Department of Public Administration and Policy, American University; Humphrey School of Public Affairs, University of Minnesota; School of Information, University of California; School of Information, University of Michigan; Warwick Business School, University of Warwick

Abstract. A primary way the US federal government delivers public goods and services is via monetary payments. Ensuring that these payments are calculated accurately, delivered on time, and made to the correct recipients is important for government fiscal health. Inaccurate or delayed payments can weaken public trust in the government and undermine government accountability. In this article, we examine findings from a set of impact evaluations assessing interventions designed to improve payment integrity in US federal programs. The low-cost, evidence-based interventions draw on insights from the social and behavioral sciences and include modification of forms, changes to how and when agencies request information, and altering existing communications. The evaluations were conducted by the US General Services Administration's Office of Evaluation Sciences in collaboration with agency partners. We extract three takeaways across four representative evaluations. First, the real-world evaluations validate a key implication of the behavioral science literature: interventions that reduce burdens for individuals have small effects that meaningfully improve payment integrity at scale. Second, effects attenuate across interventions and over time, suggesting a need for iterative evaluation. Finally, bureaucratic hurdles and administrative complexity are the main barriers to translating academic insights into real-world government programs. Addressing these challenges will require close collaboration between behavioral scientists and practitioners throughout the intervention design and evaluation process.

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Feeding health inequality through platform-based food delivery in China

2026-07-06 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2538093123

Hai Ding; Chenran Liu; Yu Xie; Jia Yu; Zhengrong Yuan

Center for Social Research, Guanghua School of Management, Peking University; Guanghua School of Management, Peking University; Paul and Marcia Center on Contemporary China, Princeton University; School of Economics, Renmin University of China; School of Economics, Zhongnan University of Economics and Law

Abstract. This study examines how the expansion of online food delivery platforms affects health inequality in China. Exploiting the staggered rollout of platforms across counties and nationally representative panel data from 2010 to 2022, we find that platform entry increases overweight among low-income individuals while reducing it among high-income individuals. This divergence operates through two channels: low-income users increase consumption of fried foods and reallocate time from cooking to sedentary leisure, whereas high-income users reduce intake of calorie-dense foods and increase physical activity. These behavioral changes accumulate into downstream health consequences affecting weight-related chronic diseases and children's overweight in low-income households. Equal access to digital convenience thus does not translate into equal health benefits, suggesting that technological diffusion may amplify health disparities.

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Applied behavioral and decision sciences in support of US FDA's drug regulatory mission

2026-07-06 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2525995123

Sara L. Eggers; Tamar Krishnamurti; Baruch Fischhoff

Department of Engineering and Public Policy and Carnegie Mellon Institute for Strategy and Technology, Carnegie Mellon University; Division of General Internal Medicine, University of Pittsburgh School of Medicine; Independent Scholar

Abstract. The US Food and Drug Administration (FDA) makes and communicates decisions that directly affect the health choices and well-being of the US public. Behavioral and decision scientists have long supported FDA's pharmaceutical (medical drug) regulatory and public health mission, working alongside clinical and pharmaceutical scientists. This Perspective describes four interrelated cases illustrating these collaborations: a) creating the Benefit-Risk Framework to guide regulatory decisions regarding new drug approvals; b) launching an internal decision support service to facilitate specific regulatory decisions; c) implementing the Patient-Focused Drug Development initiative to strengthen the use of patient input to inform regulatory decision making; and d) developing FDA SOURCE, a dynamic systems simulation model to assess potential strategies to address the US opioid overdose crisis. Key to the success of these efforts has been their behavioral and decision science foundations, strategically implemented by an expert team dedicated to fostering trusted

collaborations with internal and external partners. These cases offer a model for other agencies facing complex decisions of public impact.

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Science

Why cities cannot learn

2026-07-09 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AEH8677

Zaheer Allam

Zaheer Allam is a senior researcher at the Institute for Sustainable Futures, University of Technology Sydney, Sydney, Australia and an adjunct associate professor at the School of Architecture, Design and Planning, the University of Queensland, Brisbane, Australia.

Abstract. For most of the world's urban history, changes in policies and responses to hazards have proceeded on a timescale that made adaptation possible, however slow or politically contested. The Great Fire of London in 1666 produced building regulations within 2 years of the devastating blaze. Repeated flooding events along the Rhine and Danube Rivers through the late 20th century spurred zoning rules and hazard mapping that are now standard across Europe's urban planning systems. What drove these improvements was a general pathway in which disruption produced evidence, evidence generated pressure, and pressure forced modifications by agencies responsible for governing a city's well-being. However, that process has been degrading across every inhabited continent. What has emerged in its place is a volatile urbanism that is threatening resilience.

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A statistical test for the benefits of personalizing interventions

2026-07-09 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AEB9506

Zhaoqi Li; Emma Brunskill

Computer Science Department, Stanford University, Stanford, CA, USA.

Abstract. From medicine to marketing to social sciences, the promise of tailoring interventions to individuals is undeniable. However, practical applications force weighing personalization's potential benefits with its possible increased cost and fragility. We introduce a statistical hypothesis test that evaluates, given historical data, evidence that a personalized intervention policy's performance will surpass deploying the best single intervention. The test maintains strict Type I error control while achieving asymptotic normality with the minimal possible variance under specified conditions. Results on diverse datasets from job training, depression treatment, education, and recommendation systems demonstrate the test's versatility and its superior performance over alternatives. This test can support decision-makers throughout the intervention sciences by providing a simple and powerful quantification of the potential benefits of personalization.

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Science Advances

Communicating coral: Art and science for global reef action

2026-07-10 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.AEJ6847

Monica Medina; Or Ben-Zvi; Oren Levy

Department of Ecology and Evolutionary Biology, University of California Los Angeles, Los Angeles, CA, USA.; Faculty of Life Sciences, Bar Ilan University, Ramat Gan, Israel.; Scripps Institution of Oceanography, University of California San Diego, La Jolla, CA, USA.

Abstract. Coral reefs are experiencing unprecedented rapid decline. Art can act as a beacon to engage audiences, influence policy, and inspire global action.

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Previous Week Catch-Up

American Journal of Political Science

Bureaucrat assignments as instruments of political control: Theory and evidence from land administration officials in India

2026-07-02 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70069

Anustubh Agnihotri; Aditya Dasgupta; Devesh Kapur

Department of Political Science Ashoka University Sonapat Haryana India; Department of Political Science University of California Merced California USA; Paul H. Nitze School of Advanced International Studies (SAIS) Johns Hopkins University Washington DC USA

Abstract. Abstract This paper investigates how politicians use the assignment of officials to geographical posts-a personnel system found in many countries-as a system of incentives to control, and possibly corrupt, bureaucratic behavior. The argument is developed with a matching model and tested with a nationwide survey of Indian officials who administer land, a lucrative asset and source of rents in fastgrowing countries. With an unobtrusive design, we provide evidence that officials prefer geographical posts with urban amenities, good staffing, and hometown proximity. These preferences are intense in salaryequivalent terms. Ruling parties use this as leverage to exert pressure on officials to bend regulations by assigning them to their preferred posts but threatening transfers should they fail to comply, especially in jurisdictions with high regulatory corruption potential (measured with remotesensing data on flow of ruraltourban land transactions). The findings highlight personnel policy as a potent instrument of political control/corruption of bureaucracy.

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State surveillance and collective dissent

2026-07-01 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70057

Gaetan Nandong

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Abstract. Abstract State surveillance facilitates the collection of intelligence on dissidents while simultaneously providing information about the value of the status quo. I study this tradeoff in a context where an uninformed government must decide whether to repress. Because citizens expect more informed governments to enact greater repression, autocratic surveillance can create a climate of fear. However, surveillance can also stimulate dissent when citizens have access to public information. State surveillance gives citizens an opportunity to coordinate, even in the absence of a preference for such coordination. Surveillance can amplify dissent by enhancing citizens' motivations for political activism aimed at drawing the government's attention to political and economic issues. Coordination distorts government learning, resulting in lower expected levels of repression. The analysis further indicates that the effectiveness of advanced surveillance technology depends on expectations regarding repression, thereby underscoring a psychological aspect of state control.

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Communication Research

Partisanship in Context: The (A)symmetric Influence of Local Newspaper Availability and Selective Exposure on Political Misperceptions in the U.S.

2026-06-29 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261463581

Jianing Li; Michael W. Wagner

Rutgers, The State University of New Jersey, New Brunswick, USA; University of Wisconsin-Madison, USA

Abstract. How people consume information and understand facts is an inherently multilevel problem, but inquiry frequently stops at the individual-level. We highlight how disparities in local newspaper availability across communities influence individuals' partisan selective exposure and congruent political misperceptions. Using a quasi-experimental design enabling comparisons of individuals living in counties with different local newspaper availability but otherwise matched features, we found that lacking a local newspaper in one's county is associated with a decrease in national mainstream media use. Moreover, lacking a local newspaper amplifies partisan selective consumption of liberal media, but not conservative media. Beliefs in falsehoods disseminated by elites from both major parties in the U.S. are influenced by selective exposure and amplified by local newspaper context, while liberal media use is more sensitive to the contextual variances in local news environments than conservative media use. Findings from this unique dataset are robust against various tests of confounding effects.

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Journal of Communication

Recommending the state: How social media algorithms curate state-created content in China

2026-07-03 · DOI 10.1093/JOC/JQAG010

Yingdan Lu; Xinyi Liu; Carl Zhou

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Abstract. Abstract Authoritarian governments have increasingly expanded their social media presence, producing massive content to shape public opinion and behavior. However, less is known about how social media algorithms curate such content and serve authoritarian political goals. This study theorizes algorithmic promotional curation, whereby recommendation algorithms systematically amplify state-created content, and empirically examines this curation through analyzing 119,064 trending and recommended videos from Bilibili, one of China's largest video-sharing platforms. Using descriptive analyses, regression models, and Markov chain simulations, we find that state-created content is disproportionately amplified through video recommendations associated with state-created trending videos, and that state-affiliated accounts exhibit strong self-reinforcement. Yet this algorithmic promotional curation is not uniform across content categories, with stronger amplification among state-created news and politics than other content. These findings demonstrate how recommendation systems may subtly serve authoritarian goals, advance a multilateral understanding of algorithmic curation, and extend authoritarian information control frameworks beyond censorship and propaganda.

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Nature

Six ways to put the public at the heart of science and policy

2026-07-01 · DOI 10.1038/D41586-026-01981-Z

Chris Tyler; K. L. Akerlof; Musa al-Gharbi; Bjrn Bedsted; Laura Boeira; Tracey Brown; Elizabeth Christopherson; Dietram A. Scheufele; Mahmud Farooque; Brian W. Head; Tepring Piquado; David Budtz Pedersen

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Scientists should recognize their own political biases to build public trust

2026-07-01 · DOI 10.1038/D41586-026-01975-X

Mark Henderson

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Child online safety needs more than social-media bans

2026-06-30 · DOI 10.1038/D41586-026-02068-5

Kit-Aun Tan

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Nature Human Behaviour

An effort recalibration framework for digital media use and cognition

2026-07-01 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02500-W

Wisnu Wiradhany; Douglas Parry; Jaan Aru

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Political Communication

Does the Method Affect the Outcome? How Measures of Partisan Slant of Media Outlets and Affective Polarization Drive Results About Polarization in the United States

2026-07-05 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2699105

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Abstract. There is abundant evidence that partisan media use is related to polarization in the United States. However, there is less agreement on whether the outcomes of this exposure are detrimental to democracies. Different methods used to measure both partisan media use and polarization may have contributed to the variation in findings in this area of research. The present study relied on survey data from the 2020 U.S. presidential election to systematically examine how methodological differences in determining the partisanship of news outlets and polarization can impact outcomes of interest, such as the correlation between outlet-level partisan slant and affective as well as belief polarization. A specification curve analysis of 504 different ways of operationalizing these independent and dependent variables provided evidence that methodological choices considerably affected the strength of the relationship between partisan media use and affective and belief polarization.

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Platform Collective Behavior as Democratic Infrastructure: Beyond Causal Effects in the DSA Era

2026-06-30 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2679475

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Abstract. Online platforms have become infrastructural to democratic life, yet their influence is often examined through narrow causal-effect models that overlook systemic socio-technical dynamics. This Forum contribution introduces the concept of platform collective behavior to conceptualize how intertwined human-AI agency generates population-level patterns with systemic risk implications for democracy and citizen well-being. Rather than focusing on isolated persuasion effects, platform collective behavior captures emergent socio-algorithmic patterns such as unequal political participation, differential exposure to misinformation, bot amplification, and subgroup information segregation. The article evaluates whether Article 40 of the European Digital Services Act (DSA), which grants vetted researchers access to platform data, enables robust investigation of such systemic risks. While the DSA represents an unprecedented regulatory intervention in research data access, its scope is limited to systemic risks and depends on platform-provided datasets. The analysis identifies blind spots, including infrastructural and economic power asymmetries, offline behavioral consequences, and data integrity concerns. The article concludes that DSA access is necessary but insufficient for fully assessing platform influence on democracy.

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Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

People in more individualist cultures are more motivated to make others feel better

2026-06-30 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2533994123

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Abstract. In many Western cultures, trying to make others feel better is considered critical for psychological health and social relationships. However, given that people think about emotions and relationships differently across cultures, the desirability, means, and benefits of making others feel better may also vary by culture. In two multicountry survey studies (Study 1: N = 3,154, 13 countries; Study 2: N = 3,503, 17 countries) and in a daily diary study (Study 3: N = 243, 2 countries), we assessed motivation and strategies used for influencing others' and one's own emotions. To test whether potential cross-cultural differences in motivation and strategies in emotion regulation are unique to social interactions, we compared cultural differences in making others feel better to making oneself feel better. Across studies, cultural differences in influencing others' emotions were greater than those in influencing one's own emotions. Members of more individualist (vs. collectivist) cultures were more motivated to make others (but not themselves) feel better, were more likely to express care and less likely to encourage others to suppress their emotions or to ruminate. These patterns, in turn, were linked to an index of relationship closeness in an individualist (but not a collectivist) culture. These findings suggest that helping others feel better may not be equally desirable across cultures.

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Large language models accurately identify decision reasons in verbal reports

2026-06-30 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2526798123

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Abstract. Understanding the reasons behind human choices under risk is a central goal of decision scientists, but traditional methods relying on behavioral data are limited by strict invariance assumptions. We introduce a scalable analytical framework using large language models (LLMs) to analyze verbal reports and identify articulated reasons for choice between monetary lotteries. A validated LLM accurately identified predefined decision reasons in participants' free-text reports, aligning with their actual choices in 95% of trials. Our analysis reveals that the reasons behind people's decisions vary systematically and are driven more by the structure of the choice problem than by individual differences. Crucially, reasons identified from verbal reports yield more parsimonious and informative representations of decision processes compared to those inferred from choices alone; furthermore, problem-specific reason profiles achieve out-of-sample prediction accuracy that is competitive with established computational models. This work demonstrates that verbal reports are a rich data source and our analytical framework can unlock their potential, delivering results that challenge the field's foundational invariance assumptions and pave the way for more context-sensitive and interpretable models of human decision making.

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Debt as a blessing: A capital screening mechanism

2026-06-30 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2602272123

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Abstract. We challenge a recently popular view that a negative interest-growth rate gap ($r < g$) offers a "free lunch" for debt-financed government spending by formulating a model in which r and g are endogenous variables shaped by fiscal policy through its effects on equilibrium multiplicity and capital allocation. Observing $r < g$ can signal that sustained government deficits have generated multiple steady states, and the economy has converged to a stable low-efficiency equilibrium. With its heterogeneous entrepreneurs, the model's real interest rate serves as a screening device for investment efficiency. Causation runs from the fiscal regime to equilibrium selection and outcomes: Fiscal surpluses eliminate equilibrium multiplicity and anchor expectations that sustain a unique, high-productivity equilibrium, thereby rationalizing Alexander Hamilton's characterization of "debt as a blessing." Persistent deficits can push the economy into a "misallocation trap" characterized by scarce safe assets, low interest rates, survival of inefficient firms, depressed aggregate productivity, and self-validating low growth. Thus, costs of debt-financed fiscal deficits consist not only of deferred taxes, but also of permanently lower national productive capacity.

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Local partisan context and mental health

2026-06-29 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2522718123

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Abstract. We find that, relative to Republicans residing in more Republican neighborhoods, Republicans in neighborhoods with a higher concentration of Democratic residents report higher levels of anxiety, depression, and loneliness. While

Democrats in general report worse mental health than Republicans, Democrats show no sensitivity to partisan context. Using a large-scale national survey and fine-grained data on residential political context, we establish that these patterns persist even when examining partisans who live in the same Zip Codes, and while controlling for other individual and geographic features. The correlation is strongest for the most strongly partisan individuals, suggesting that politics is a significant factor in the relationship. For Republicans, the size of the relationship between partisan context and mental health is comparable to or larger than the correlation between mental health reports and other contextual features of residential areas, such as neighborhood poverty or the way racial minorities respond to changes in the racial or ethnic composition of local geography.

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Science

Institutionalizing AI diplomacy in Africa

2026-07-02 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AEI7835

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Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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From Edison's Invention Factory to the new architecture of innovation

2026-07-02 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AEI5415

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Abstract. Shifts reflect the maturation of institutions surrounding science

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Science Advances

Community Notes undermoderate polarizing content by design creating risks in electoral processes

2026-07-03 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.AEE6932

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Abstract. Community Notes of X enables users to collaboratively moderate misleading content. To resolve conflicting moderation, Community Notes infers a latent ideological dimension and selects notes garnering cross-partisan support. As this system is now deployed worldwide, we evaluate its operation across diverse polarization contexts. We analyze all 1.9 million moderation notes receiving 135 million ratings by March 2025, cross-referencing ideological scaling data on 13 countries. Our results show that the Community Notes algorithm effectively captures the main polarizing dimensions across countries, surfacing notes that garner cross-partisan support. This also means that, by design, Community Notes systematically undermoderate polarizing content. We analyze notes relating to four recent elections in the United States (2024), the United Kingdom (2024), France (2024), and Germany (2025) and demonstrate that they are systematically undermoderated when compared to other notes, posing potential risks to civic discourse and electoral processes.

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